CYBER SAFETY GUY

SEXTORTION & IMAGE-BASED ABUSE:

A PARENT'S PLAIN-ENGLISH GUIDE

Sextortion is when someone tricks, threatens or blackmails a child using intimate images or videos. It is not your child's fault. Help and support are available.

Here's what parents need to know.

1 IN 7
teens are targeted by online predators before 18
Thorn (2023)

90%
of sextortion victims are threatened with image sharing
NCA (2023)

24/7
sextortion can happen at any time, anywhere
IWF (2023)

MOST
victims know the person who blackmails them
NCA (2023)

1 WHAT IT IS
Sextortion is blackmail. Someone threatens to share intimate images or videos.

2 HOW IT HAPPENS
They build trust. They ask for images. Then they threaten or demand more.

3 HOW THEY CONTACT
Social media, gaming, messaging apps, dating sites and hidden/anon apps.

4 WHAT THEY WANT
Money, more images, favours or to keep the secret. They may never stop.

5 WHY IT WORKS
They exploit fear, embarrassment and shame to keep victims silent.

6 CONVERSATION
Talk early. Listen often. Keep it open and judgement-free.

HOW SEXTORTION HAPPENS

CONTACT → They reach out and build a friendship.

TRUST → They gain trust and attention (often flattery).

REQUEST → They ask for intimate photos or videos.

THREAT → They threaten to share or send to friends/family.

EXTORT → They demand money, more images or favours

WHAT PARENTS NEED TO UNDERSTAND

1. **It can happen to anyone.**
   Kind, smart and careful kids can still be targeted.
2. **It is not your child's fault.**
   The blame lies with the person doing the harm.
3. **Silence protects the blackmailer.**
   Talking early reduces harm and stops it escalating.

Your support can make all the difference.

BY THE NUMBERS

79%
of sextortion victims are male
NCA (2023)

30%
of victims are under 16
Thorn (2023)

50%+
of reports started on social media platforms
IWF (2023)

UP TO 18 MONTHS
some victims are blackmailed for
NCA (2023)

SAFETY FEATURES & SETTINGS

WHAT EXISTS

Privacy Controls
Limit who can contact your child.

Blocking & Reporting
Block and report users or content.

Disappearing Messages
Messages can auto-delete in some apps.

Report to Authorities
Platforms can pass reports to police.

WHAT TO DO

- Review privacy settings together.
- Limit who can message, comment or follow.
- Turn off location sharing where possible.
- Check app age ratings and use family tools.

STEP-BY-STEP: WHAT TO DO

1. **STAY CALM**
   Reacting in anger or panic can make things worse.
2. **DON'T PAY OR COMPLY**
   Paying encourages more demands. It doesn't solve it.
3. **SAVE THE EVIDENCE**
   Take screenshots. Save usernames, messages, dates.
4. **BLOCK THE PERSON**
   Block and report across all platforms and accounts.
5. **REPORT IT**
   Report to the platform and to the police.
6. **GET SUPPORT**
   Talk to someone you trust. You are not alone.

THE RISKS WORTH KNOWING

Emotional Harm
Anxiety, shame and depression can follow.

Image Sharing
Images may be shared with friends, school or online.

Ongoing Blackmail
Demands can continue for months or years.

Financial Loss
Victims may be pressured for money or gift cards.

Damage to Reputation
Photos or videos can affect school, friendships and future.

Escalation
Threats of self-harm or violence can be used to control.

THE 10-MINUTE CONVERSATION



- What apps do you use to chat or game?
- Do you know anyone online that you haven't met in real life?
- Would you tell me if someone asked for nudes or personal pics?
- Do you know you can come to me, no matter what?

TRUST OVER SURVEILLANCE
Connection, not control, keeps kids safe.

IF THINGS GO WRONG

STAY CALM & GATHER EVIDENCE

- Don't delete anything.
- Take screenshots of chats, profiles and threats.
- Note dates, times and any payment requests.
- Keep the evidence safe.

REPORT & SEEK HELP

- Report to the platform immediately.
- Report to CEOP: report.ceop.police.uk
- Call Childline: 0800 1111 (free, 24/7)
- Get help from your school if needed.

You did the right thing. Help is available.

NEED TO TALK? CHILDLINE

0800 1111
childline.org.uk

YOU ARE NOT ALONE
We're here for you.